

Butter Bean, Mushroom & Walnut Loaf

A simply prepared vegetarian centrepiece — deeply savoury, slices cleanly at the table. Fits the omega 3/6 strategy throughout.

SERVES 6

INGREDIENTS

2	tins butter beans (400g each), drained and rinsed
400g	chestnut mushrooms, finely chopped
25g	dried porcini mushrooms
1	large onion, finely diced
4	garlic cloves, minced
100g	walnuts, roughly chopped
2	eggs, beaten
3 tbsp	olive oil
1 tbsp	tamari or soy sauce
1 tsp	dried thyme
½ tsp	dried rosemary, crushed
	salt and black pepper
1 tbsp	olive oil, for the tin

METHOD

1. Soak the porcini

Place the dried porcini in a small bowl and cover with 150ml of just-boiled water. Set aside to soak for at least 20 minutes. Once soaked, drain and reserve the liquid — refrigerate or freeze it for use in a gravy another time. Roughly chop the porcini.

2. Toast the walnuts

Toast the walnuts in a dry frying pan over medium heat until fragrant and just starting to colour. Set aside.

3. Cook the onion and garlic

Heat the olive oil in a large frying pan over medium-low heat. Add the onion, dried thyme and crushed rosemary and cook gently until the onion is completely soft. Add the garlic and cook for a further 2 minutes.

4. Cook down the mushrooms

Add the chestnut mushrooms and turn the heat up to medium-high. Cook, stirring occasionally, until all moisture has evaporated and the mushrooms are deeply coloured and almost dry. Add the chopped porcini and tamari. Season well. Cook for 2 more minutes then set aside to cool slightly.

5. Prepare the tin

Preheat your oven to 200°C / 180°C fan. Line a 900g loaf tin with baking parchment and brush with olive oil.

6. Make the filling

Tip the butter beans into a large bowl and roughly mash — mostly smooth but with some texture remaining. Add the mushroom mixture, toasted walnuts, and beaten eggs. Mix thoroughly. Taste and adjust seasoning. If the mixture feels very wet, stir in a tablespoon of oats.

7. Fill the tin

Spoon the mixture into the prepared tin, pressing it down firmly and smoothing the top. A compact, even fill will help it slice cleanly.

8. Roast

Roast for 35–40 minutes until the top is firm and well coloured.

9. Rest and serve

Leave in the tin for 10 minutes before turning out — this is important for clean slices. Turn onto a board, remove the parchment, and slice with a sharp serrated knife.

NOTES

Porcini liquid: Strain through a fine sieve and keep in the fridge for up to 3 days, or freeze. It makes an excellent base for a porcini and red wine miso gravy.

Texture: Don't over-mash the beans — some texture makes for a better slice and a more interesting bite alongside the walnut chunks.

Getting ahead: The filling can be made up to a day ahead and kept in the fridge. Spoon into the tin and roast when needed.